Literature: General

H 1775

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A. Background

This instruction sheet provides a general overview of the assignment of subject headings in the field of literature. Specific instructions are given in other instruction sheets, especially those listed in section C, below.

LC practice: As stated in H 1075, LC catalogers will no longer use form subdivisions. Instead assign an appropriate term or terms from Library of Congress Genre/Form Terms (LCGFT), e.g. ***Drama***, ***Free verse***, etc. To replace a form subdivision that includes a demographic group, also assign Library of Congress Demographic Groups Terms (LCDGT) to bring out the audience of the resource being cataloged, e.g. ***Children***, ***German speakers***, etc.

B. Recent revisions

2026-01: Updated template. Added instructions related to LCGFT implementation.

C. Most commonly used instruction sheets

The following instruction sheets are of particular interest for the assignment of subject headings in the field of literature.

Lists of free-floating subdivisions:

- H 1110 Names of Persons (includes individual literary authors)
- H 1155.2 Groups of Literary Authors
- H 1155.6 Literary Works Entered Under Author
- H 1155.8 Literary Works Entered Under Title
- H 1156 Literatures

Assignment of subject headings:

- H 910 Place as a Theme in Art, Literature, Motion Pictures, Etc.
- H 1430 Comics and Comic Characters
- H 1435 Commentaries on Individual Works
- H 1610 Fictitious Characters
- H 1627 Folklore
- H 1690 Juvenile Materials
- H 1780 Drama
- H 1790 Fiction
- H 1795 Legends and Romances
- H 1800 Poetry
- H 1828 Literature from One Place in Multiple Languages
- H 2220 Translations

D. Most commonly expressed concepts in subject headings for literature

The following concepts are frequently encountered in the cataloging of literary materials. These concepts are expressed in the assignment of subject headings according to the type of work being cataloged as explained in section E, below.

Concept	Examples
Nationality	American, Mexican, Swiss
Form or genre	poetry, short stories, one-act plays
Theme or topic	love, mystery, Napoleon, Korean War
Time period	20th century, Renaissance
Special group of authors	Jews, women, prisoners

Translations	from French into English
Movements	Romanticism, Surrealism
Languages	Basque, Yiddish, Catalan
Locality where written	New York City, Normandy, Southern States

E. Most commonly found types of works in literature cataloging

The following are the six basic categories of works found in the field of literature.

E.1. Collections of literary texts by several authors

Examples:

a collection of 20th century American poetry

an anthology of German literature

selections from classical Spanish drama

English translations of Portuguese love poems

Any of the concepts in section D, above, may be expressed for this category of work. Subdivisions are normally used to express time period, translations, and locality. Form or genre is normally combined with nationality or language in a phrase heading, for example, ***American poetry***. Themes or topics may be expressed as ***[topic]--[subdivision]***, for example, ***Cats--Literary collections***; or as a phrase, for example, ***Detective and mystery stories***. Groups of authors may be expressed as subdivisions or as phrases, e.g. ***American fiction--Women authors***; ***Soldiers' writings, Canadian***.

LC practice: Do not use form subdivisions. Instead assign an appropriate term or terms from LCGFT, e.g. ***Drama*** or ***Free verse***. To replace a form subdivision that includes a demographic group, also assign LCDGT to bring out the audience of the resource being cataloged, e.g. ***Children***, ***German speakers***, etc.

E.2. Collections of literary texts by one author

Examples:

a collection of poems of one author

complete work of a novelist

selected short stories of one author

Theme or topic is expressed for this category of work; genre may be shown if highly specific and emphasized in the work. Nationality or language is expressed only if combined with genre or theme in a phrase heading, for example, ***Sonnets, American***; ***Romance fiction, French***. Translations are shown by subdivision under the name of the author, for example, ***Poe, Edgar**

Allan, 1809-1849--Translations into French*. Other concepts from sec. D, above, are not expressed.

LC practice: Do not use form subdivisions. Instead assign an appropriate term or terms from LCGFT, e.g. ***Drama*** or ***Free verse***. To replace a form subdivision that includes a demographic group, also assign LCDGT to bring out the audience of the resource being cataloged, e.g. ***Children***, ***German speakers***, etc.

E.3. Single literary text

Examples:

```
a single novel
a single play
```

Individual poems or plays are assigned headings for theme and for highly specific forms, for example, ***Christmas--Poetry***; ***Monodramas***. Individual works of fiction are assigned headings for persons, historical events or periods, and animals, for example, ***Washington, George, 1732-1799--Fiction***; ***Thirty Years' War, 1618-1648--Fiction***; ***Horses--Fiction***. Other concepts from section D, above, are not normally expressed.

LC practice: Do not use form subdivisions. Instead assign an appropriate term or terms from LCGFT, e.g. ***Drama*** or ***Free verse***. To replace a form subdivision that includes a demographic group, also assign LCDGT to bring out the audience of the resource being cataloged, e.g. ***Children***, ***German speakers***, etc.

E.4. Discussion of several authors

Examples:

```
a history of Argentine literature
a bibliography of French science fiction
essays on 20th century Jewish novelists
treatise on the use of satire in American novels
biographical directory of Canadian authors
```

Any of the concepts from section D, above, may be expressed. Subdivisions must be added to literary form headings to show that the work is about literature, not a collection of texts; the most common of these subdivisions is ***--History and criticism***. Themes or topics are usually expressed as ***[topic] in literature***, ***[topic]--In literature***, or ***[topic] and literature***.

LC practice: Do not use form subdivisions. Instead assign an appropriate term or terms from LCGFT, e.g. ***Bibliographies*** or ***Essays***.

E.5. Discussion of one author

Examples:

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autobiography of a single author
stage history of Shakespeare's plays
a treatise on Victor Hugo's poetry
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The major subject heading assigned is the name of the author discussed, with subdivisions as appropriate from the pattern lists of free-floating subdivisions. Theme or topic may also be expressed. Other concepts from section D, above, are not normally expressed. Biographical works follow provisions for biography given in H 1330.

LC practice: Do not use form subdivisions. Instead assign an appropriate term or terms from LCGFT, e.g. ***Biographies***.

E.6. Discussion of single literary text

Examples:

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essays on Milton's Paradise lost
treatise on Margaret Mitchell's Gone with the wind
```

The major subject heading assigned is the uniform title for the work, usually as an author-title subject entry. Subdivisions may be assigned from the appropriate pattern list. Theme or topic may also be expressed. Form headings or subdivisions that were assigned to the literary text are converted to the appropriate topical equivalent. Other concepts from section D, above, are not normally expressed.

LC practice: Do not use form subdivisions. Instead assign an appropriate term or terms from LCGFT, e.g. ***Essays***.

Revision history

2026-01: Updated template. Added instructions related to LCGFT implementation.